

Pyroclastic flow An avalanche of very hot rock and dust that cascades down the flank of an erupting volcano.

Radiation Light, heat, or other forms of energy such as X-rays that spread out through space from a source such as a star or a glowing object.

Reservoir A store of something, usually a liquid such as water.

Rift A widening crack in rocks or in Earth's crust, formed by tectonic plates drifting apart.

Rift valley A region where part of Earth's crust has dropped into the gap formed by the crust pulling apart.

Satellite Something that orbits (circles) a planet. The Moon is a natural satellite, but many of Earth's satellites are artificial, including the International Space Station, the Hubble Space Telescope, and dozens of communication, weather, and navigation satellites.

Scavenger An animal that eats the remains of dead animals and other scraps.

Sediment Solid particles such as sand, silt, or mud that have settled on the sea bed or elsewhere.

Sedimentary Describes a deposit or rock made of sediments.

Seismic Relating to earth movements caused by earthquakes.

Solar radiation Heat, light, and other forms of energy generated by the Sun.

Solar System The system of planets, moons, and asteroids orbiting the Sun.

Species The basic unit of classification of living organisms. For example, a tiger is a species of cat. Members of a species can reproduce by pairing with one another, but not with other species. A subspecies forms when there is a barrier—often geographical—between two populations of the same species.

Stalactite A cone-shaped structure created when groundwater deposits minerals on a cave roof.

Stalagmite A pedestal-shaped structure created when water drips from the tip of a stalactite and deposits minerals on a cave floor.

Star An object in space that is massive enough to generate energy by nuclear fusion reactions. The Sun is a star.

Strata Layers of sedimentary rock.

Stratosphere The layer of Earth's atmosphere that lies above the lowest layer (the troposphere).

Subduction The process of one plate of Earth's crust sliding beneath another, creating an ocean trench, causing earthquakes, and fueling volcanoes.

Subtropics The warm regions to the north and south of the equator that lie between the hot tropics and the cooler midlatitudes.

Tectonic plate Any one of about 17 pieces of Earth's rigid shell (made up of the crust and upper mantle) that drift slowly over the planet's surface.

Temperate A climate that is neither very hot nor very cold, or a region that has such a climate.

Trade wind A wind that blows steadily from east to west over a tropical ocean.

Tropics The hot regions to the north and south of the equator, between the Tropic of Cancer and the Tropic of Capricorn.

Troposphere The lowest layer of the atmosphere, where the weather happens.

Tsunami A fast-moving ocean wave generated by an earthquake on the ocean floor, by the collapse of an oceanic volcano, or by a coastal landslide.

Tundra The cold, almost treeless landscape that lies on the fringes of the polar ice sheets.

Ultraviolet Energy radiated by the Sun that is invisible, but attacks living tissues and destroys them.

Warm front The leading edge of a moving mass of warm air, where it slides up over a mass of cold air.

Water vapor The gas that forms when liquid water is warmed and evaporates.

Weathering The breaking down of rocks and minerals by rain, sunlight, ice, and other climatic effects.

Westerly wind A wind that blows from west to east.

Zooplankton Animals that mainly drift in the water, although some may also swim actively.

